The Great Society

President Lyndon B. Johnson · commencement address · University of Michigan · May 22, 1964

Source: Lyndon B. Johnson, Remarks at the University of Michigan (May 22, 1964), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Johnson used this Michigan commencement address to roll out the name for his domestic program. Within the next two years Congress would pass an extraordinary burst of legislation: the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Voting Rights Act of 1965, Medicare and Medicaid, the Elementary and Secondary Education Act, Head Start, the War on Poverty, the Immigration Act of 1965, and federal housing programs. The Great Society was both the high-water mark of mid-century American liberalism and a target of conservative backlash that shaped politics for the next 50+ years.

Connect: The Great Society expanded federal power much like FDR's New Deal (Class 45). Compare their targets: what problems did each try to solve?

Key Passages

The vision

> The Great Society rests on abundance and liberty for all. It demands an end to poverty and racial injustice, to which we are totally committed in our time. But that is just the beginning. The Great Society is a place where every child can find knowledge to enrich his mind and to enlarge his talents. … But most of all, the Great Society is not a safe harbor, a resting place, a final objective, a finished work. It is a challenge constantly renewed

Creative federalism

> The solution to these problems does not rest on a massive program in Washington, nor can it rely solely on the strained resources of local authority. They require us to create new concepts of cooperation, a creative federalism, between the National Capital and the leaders of local communities.

On the choice

> So, will you join in the battle to give every citizen the full equality which God enjoins and the law requires, whatever his belief, or race, or the color of his skin? Will you join in the battle to give every citizen an escape from the crushing weight of poverty? … Will you join in the battle to build the Great Society, to prove that our material progress is only the foundation on which we will build a richer life of mind and spirit?

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Prosperity of the 1960s alongside poverty and racial injustice; Johnson took office after JFK's assassination and was running for election in 1964.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	University of Michigan graduates and, through the press, the American public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Lyndon Johnson, a Democrat and New Deal-era politician who believed government could end poverty and expand opportunity.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Place the Great Society in the broader trajectory of 20th-century federal expansion (Progressive Era → New Deal → Great Society).
2. Identify TWO specific Great Society programs and what each was designed to do.
3. How did the Vietnam War complicate the Great Society's funding and political support?